Myth versus Reality

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I distinctly recall one sentence from Rahul Gandhi that caught my (and many in my peer group's) undivided attention. He unequivocally said, 'People may or may not join me, but I will start and complete this Yatra.' He went on to assert that while the Bharat Jodo Yatra was being organized by the Congress party, it belonged to every Indian. To underscore this point, it was decided that the standard (flag) of the Yatra would not be the party flag but the Tricolour. This clever reclaiming of nationalism tugged at every Indian's patriotism, which is why organized troll armies had to mellow down (after an initial vicious and underhanded attack on the Yatra and Rahul Gandhi). This appeal to the nation was widely appreciated, and Indians cutting across caste, creed, class and gender responded to Rahul Gandhi's earnest appeal.

In that spirit, Dakshinayan (under the overall stewardship of Dr Ganesh Devy) worked tirelessly to increase participation from various social organizations in Maharashtra. Dakshinayan was joined by more than 200 such social organizations in Maharashtra alone, and many prominent ones spontaneously did the same across India (including the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan, Ekta Parishad, Lokayat, Swaraj India, Chhatra Bharati, Vidrohi Sanskrutik Manch, Satyashodhak Vidyarthi Sanghatana and Makam). Although we didn't know it at the time, this happened without any central leadership or coordination. Almost like divine intervention, a hundred flowers blossomed across India. Since I was crucially involved with Dakshinayan and am aware of what happened in Maharashtra, I will focus on that process. We all started working tirelessly to mobilize our respective networks and appealing to people to join this people's Yatra. For